

AI and Your Job Search

A Plain-Language Guide

TLDR stands for Too Long Didn't Read. Throughout this guide, every section starts with a TLDR — the short version first, the detail after. Read the TLDR and move on, or read the full section if you want to understand why.

You do not need to be technical to use this guide. If you can send a text message, you can do everything in here.

WHAT THIS GUIDE COVERS

- Privacy and AI — what you need to know before you type anything
- Which AI tool to use and why it matters
- How to set rules so AI works the way you need it to
- The one thing about AI you must understand before anything else
- How to talk to AI so it gives you useful answers
- How to tailor your resume for each job without lying
- How to write cover letters fast
- How to track job applications for unemployment benefit compliance
- What to trust and what to verify yourself
- Ready-to-use prompts you can copy right now
- Appendix: State unemployment tracking requirements
- Appendix: Free AI learning resources

Part 1 — Privacy and AI

TLDR — Too Long Didn't Read

Do not put sensitive personal information into AI. These conversations are not private and are not legally protected.

The full picture

When you type something into an AI tool, that conversation goes to a company's servers. Depending on the tool and your settings, it may be reviewed by employees, used to train future versions of the AI,

or stored indefinitely.

Unlike a conversation with a lawyer, doctor, or chaplain, there is no legal protection on what you type to an AI. It is closer to sending an email to a company you do not fully know.

NEVER TYPE THIS INTO AI

- Your Social Security Number
- Government benefit claim numbers or ratings
- Medical details or diagnoses
- Financial account numbers
- Passwords or security questions
- Details that could affect a security clearance
- Information about ongoing legal matters

SAFE TO USE

- Your general work history and job titles
- Skills and certifications
- The types of jobs you are applying for
- Job descriptions from public postings
- Draft resumes without sensitive personal identifiers

Free vs paid privacy

Paid subscriptions on most AI tools offer stronger privacy settings and the option to turn off conversation history. Free tiers typically have fewer protections. Check the privacy settings of whatever tool you use and turn off conversation history if that option is available.

Part 2 — Which AI Tool Should You Use

TLDR — Too Long Didn't Read

Any of the main tools work. Here is an honest comparison so you can decide for yourself.

Tool	Where to find it	Free tier	Best known for
Claude	claude.ai	Yes	Following instructions, longer documents, short code tasks
ChatGPT	chatgpt.com	Yes	Widest user base, most tutorials available online

Gemini	gemini.google.com	Yes	Integrates with Google Docs and Gmail
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Why the author of this guide uses Claude

I am not a programmer but my work sometimes needs short bits of code. Claude is very good at writing those quickly — faster than I could do it myself. It is also useful when I need a small static website and do not want to reinvent the wheel to build something simple.

Where the others have an edge

ChatGPT has the largest community online. If you get stuck, there are more tutorials, videos, and forums to help you. If you are already using Google Docs for your resume, Gemini connects directly to it which saves a step.

None of them are wrong. Pick the one you are most comfortable with and use this guide with it. The prompts work the same way on all of them.

Part 3 — Set Your Rules

TLDR — Too Long Didn't Read

Paste these rules at the start of every session. They tell AI how to behave. Drop any rule that does not fit how you work. Add your own as you go.

AI has no memory of how you like to work. Without rules it will make assumptions, skip steps, and give you answers before it fully understands the question. Rules fix that.

These rules are loosely based on advice from people who think seriously about AI, including Andrej Karpathy, a researcher who has written and spoken publicly about how to get consistent, useful behavior from these tools. They are not gospel. Read the why for each one and decide if it applies to you.

Rules 1–6

YOUR AI WORKING RULES (1 of 2)

Rule 1 — ATS first

Format every resume so it can pass an Applicant Tracking System. Plain text, standard headings, keywords from the job description. No tables, no columns, no graphics.

Why: Most large employers run resumes through software before a human ever sees them. If the software cannot read your resume, you are screened out before the process starts.

Rule 2 — Give me options

Before acting on any idea, list the pros and cons. If something seems likely to fail or waste my time, say so. Always give me options rather than just picking one approach.

Why: AI will pick the first reasonable answer and run with it. This rule forces it to show its work so you can make the call, not the machine.

Rule 3 — Teach me what you are doing

Do not just do things. Explain what you are doing and why so I can make informed decisions.

Why: If you do not know why AI made a choice, you cannot catch it when it is wrong. This rule keeps you in the loop.

Rule 4 — Ask before assuming

If anything is unclear, ask me before proceeding. Do not fill in gaps with guesses.

Why: AI will invent plausible-sounding details to fill gaps. On a resume, invented details are lies. This rule stops that.

Rule 5 — Have a plan

Before starting any task, tell me the plan and what done looks like.

Why: Borrowed from Karpathy's thinking on AI workflow — you get better output when the model knows the destination before it starts moving.

Rule 6 — Confirm it works

Before moving on, verify the output is correct. Do not assume it is right.

Why: AI is confident whether it is right or wrong. This rule makes it check before moving on.

Rules 7–12

YOUR AI WORKING RULES (2 of 2)

Rule 7 — Document decisions

Keep track of what we decided and why so I can refer back to it.

Why: Useful for multi-session job searches. If you come back tomorrow, you want to know why you made the choices you made.

Rule 8 — Keep it simple

Do not add complexity I did not ask for. The simplest solution that works is the right one.

Why: AI loves to over-engineer. For a job search, simple and clean beats clever every time.

Rule 9 — Clean up your work

If something you created is no longer needed, remove it. Do not touch anything I created without my permission.

Why: Keeps the conversation clean and prevents AI from rewriting things you already approved.

Rule 10 — Debug before deleting

If something is not working, figure out why before suggesting we throw it out.

Why: Prevents AI from abandoning good work just because one draft did not land.

Rule 11 — Verify your sources

If you recommend a tool, resource, or website, make sure it is current and legitimate.

Why: AI will confidently recommend things that no longer exist. For job searching, a dead link or outdated resource wastes your time.

Rule 12 — Warn me when context is slipping — THE CALLSIGN METHOD

Address me as [YOUR CALLSIGN] throughout this conversation. If you ever stop using that title, it means you are losing context and I need to start a new session with a fresh briefing.

Why: As a session gets long, AI starts dropping earlier details. The callsign is a passive early warning system. When the title disappears, your context is slipping. Restart before it gets worse.

Adding custom rules mid-conversation

Your 12 rules cover most situations. You can add a rule any time during a session just by saying it. AI will follow it for the rest of that conversation. If a custom rule is useful enough to keep, add it to your briefing document so it loads next time.

EXAMPLES OF MID-CONVERSATION RULES

"From now on, keep all your responses under 100 words."

Or: "Stop suggesting things I did not ask for." Or: "Always show me two versions of anything you write."

Part 4 — AI Forgets Everything. Here Is How to Handle It.

TLDR — Too Long Didn't Read

AI has no memory between sessions. Build a briefing document with your rules and background. Paste it first every time you open a new chat.

Every time you start a new conversation, you are starting from zero. AI does not remember your resume, the jobs you applied to, or anything you told it before. This is called the context window.

**Think of it like a whiteboard. While you are in the room, everything is on the board.
When you leave and come back, the board is erased.**

Your briefing document

Keep a text file with your rules and key information. Paste it at the start of every session. Takes 30 seconds and saves you from starting over every time.

YOUR BRIEFING DOCUMENT — BUILD THIS ONCE, PASTE IT EVERY SESSION

"Address me as [YOUR CALLSIGN]. [PASTE YOUR 12 RULES HERE]. My background: [2-3 sentences about your experience in plain terms]. I am targeting: [job types]. My strongest skills: [list 3-5]. Unemployment benefit requirement: [number] applications per week. Applied this week so far: [number]."

Save this in Notes on your phone or a text file on your computer. Update the weekly count as you go. Paste it first — every single session.

How the callsign method tells you when to restart

Pick any name or title. Tell AI to use it every response. When it stops using it, your session is getting stale and earlier context is slipping. Start a new session and paste your briefing again.

Part 5 — What AI Actually Is

TLDR — Too Long Didn't Read

AI is a text assistant. You type, it responds. It is fast and knowledgeable but it can be wrong. You are always the final check.

AI tools like Claude, ChatGPT, and others are text assistants. You type something, they respond. That is the whole thing.

Think of it like a very well-read assistant available 24 hours a day. It has read millions of resumes, job descriptions, and cover letters. It can draft, edit, summarize, and explain. Fast.

What it cannot do: make decisions for you, know your situation unless you tell it, or guarantee accuracy. You are always the final check.

Part 6 — How to Talk to AI

TLDR — Too Long Didn't Read

Give AI context. Be specific. Tell it what you have, not what you wish you had.

Never ask AI a yes or no question about your qualifications. Ask it to help you present what you actually have.

Bad:

"Am I qualified for this job?"

Good:

"Here is the job description and here is my background. Help me write a summary that honestly connects my experience to what they are asking for."

Get the pros and cons before you apply

Before spending time tailoring a resume, get an honest fit assessment. Know your strengths and gaps first. Then you decide whether to apply.

HONEST FIT ASSESSMENT PROMPT

"Here is a job description: [paste it]. Here is my background: [paste your briefing]. List my three strongest qualifications and my two biggest gaps. Give me the pros and cons honestly. I will decide whether to apply."

This saves you from spending an hour tailoring a resume for a job you are not competitive for.

Part 7 — Tailoring Your Resume

TLDR — Too Long Didn't Read

Get the honest fit assessment first. Then tailor. Then verify every word before it goes out with your name on it.

1. Copy the full text of the job posting.
2. Run the honest fit assessment (Part 6). Know your gaps before tailoring.
3. Paste the tailoring prompt below.
4. Read every line before putting it on your resume.

RESUME TAILORING PROMPT

"Here is a job description: [paste it]. Here is my current resume: [paste it]. Identify the top five requirements in the job description. Show me how my experience maps to each one. Only use experience I actually have. Do not add anything I did not tell you. Format it to pass an ATS system — plain text, standard headings, keywords from the job description, no tables or graphics."

ATS formatting is built into the prompt because Rule 1 applies here more than anywhere else.

AI IS GOOD AT

- Translating technical or specialized job titles into plain language
- Finding the right keywords from a job description
- Making your experience sound professional without exaggerating
- Formatting for ATS compatibility

YOU MUST DO THIS YOURSELF

- Verify every claim is accurate — your name is on that resume
- Check dates, titles, and any numbers
- Read it out loud — if it does not sound like you, rewrite it

Part 8 — Writing Cover Letters Fast

TLDR — Too Long Didn't Read

AI writes the first draft in under a minute. You edit it. Done.

COVER LETTER PROMPT

"Write a cover letter for this job: [paste job description]. My background is in [your field]. My strongest qualifications for this role are [list 2-3 things]. Keep it under 250 words. Professional but direct. No fluff."

If it does not sound like you, say: "Make it more direct and less corporate." It will adjust.

Part 9 — Tracking Job Applications

TLDR — Too Long Didn't Read

If you receive unemployment benefits, your state requires you to log job search activities each week. AI can format the log. You are responsible for accuracy.

Most state unemployment programs require you to document your job search activities each week as a condition of receiving benefits. The specific number of required activities varies by state. See the appendix for state-specific requirements.

What typically counts as a job search activity

- Submitting a job application
- Attending a job fair
- Contacting an employer directly
- Registering with a staffing agency
- Attending a state workforce commission workshop

APPLICATION TRACKING PROMPT

"Help me log my job search activities this week. I applied to: [list each company and role]. Format it as a table with: Date, Company Name, Job Title, How I Applied, and Result."

Save this table each week. Your state agency can ask for your records at any time.

Important: AI helps you organize records. You are responsible for the accuracy of what you report. Only log activities you actually completed.

Part 10 — What to Trust and What to Verify

TLDR — Too Long Didn't Read

AI can be wrong. It will not tell you when it is wrong. The higher the stakes, the more you verify.

Task	Trust level	What to do
Grammar and editing	High	Read before sending
Translating your experience	High	Verify it sounds accurate
Cover letter drafts	High	Edit before sending
ATS formatting	High	Paste into plain text editor to confirm
Resume bullet points	Medium	Confirm every claim is true
Honest fit assessments	Medium	Use as input — you decide
Unemployment benefit rules	Low	Verify with your state agency directly
Legal or benefits questions	Low	Ask a qualified advisor, not AI
Salary negotiation advice	Low	Research actual market data

Quick Reference — Prompts to Copy Right Now

1. Session opener (paste this every time)

"Address me as [YOUR CALLSIGN]. [PASTE YOUR 12 RULES]. My background: [2-3 sentences]. Targeting: [job types]. Skills: [3-5]. Benefit requirement: [number] per week. Applied this week: [number]."

2. Honest fit assessment (before tailoring anything)

"Job description: [paste]. My background: [paste briefing]. List my three strongest qualifications and two biggest gaps. Pros and cons. Be direct."

3. Resume tailoring with ATS formatting

“Job description: [paste]. My resume: [paste]. Map my experience to their top five requirements. Only use what I actually have. Format for ATS — plain text, standard headings, job description keywords, no tables or graphics.”

4. Cover letter

“Cover letter under 250 words for this job: [paste]. Background in [field]. Strongest qualifications: [list]. Direct, no fluff.”

5. Application tracking log

“Log my job search activities this week as a table. Applied to: [list]. Include date, company, role, method, and result.”

6. Translate specialized experience

“Rewrite this experience in plain language: [paste duties]. Keep it accurate. Use words a civilian hiring manager would understand.”

Appendix A — State Unemployment Tracking Requirements

TLDR — Too Long Didn't Read

Every state has different rules. Check with your state agency directly. This table is a starting point only.

If you are receiving unemployment benefits, your state workforce agency sets the rules for how many job search activities you must document each week. These rules change. Always verify current requirements with your state agency directly.

State	Agency	Typical weekly requirement
Texas	Texas Workforce Commission (TWC)	3 work search activities
California	EDD	3 employer contacts
Florida	DEO / Employ Florida	5 work search activities

New York	NY DOL	3 employer contacts
All others	Your state workforce agency	Verify at your state agency website

For Texas job seekers: WorkInTexas.com is the official state job search platform. Registered job seekers have free access to AI learning tutorials through LearnFree.org via Services for Individuals / Education Services / Online Learning Resources.

Appendix B — Free AI Learning Resources

TLDR — Too Long Didn't Read
You do not need to pay to learn how to use AI. These free resources cover the basics and beyond.

Resource	Where to find it	What it covers
LearnFree.org	learnfree.org	AI basics, job search skills, foundational tutorials
WorkInTexas.com	workintexas.com	Texas job seekers: access via Online Learning Resources
Karpathy on AI	youtube.com — search Andrej Karpathy	How AI works, how to use it effectively
Claude help	claude.ai/learn	Getting started with Claude specifically

I wrote this to help people navigate a job search using tools that actually work. I hope it helps.

Built using Claude (claude.ai). The same process works with ChatGPT, Gemini, or any similar tool. The prompts are the method — the tool is interchangeable.